Donroe Doctrine will survive midterm losses

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Trump will advance Donroe Doctrine despite midterm losses

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US President Donald Trump's resounding defeat in last week’s midterms is unlikely to dramatically affect his Latin America agenda, which depends largely on executive action, though his regional policies, particularly Venezuela oil ties, will face more scrutiny in a Democratic-controlled Congress.
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That said, any resulting cabinet changes could shape regional policy, with Secretary of State Marco Rubio likely to push for an electoral timeline in Venezuela and change in Cuba before potentially leaving his post, and Treasury Secretary Scott Bessant’s tenure critical for extraordinary Argentina support.
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Ties with Brazil are unlikely to deteriorate dramatically, and conservative leaders in the region will likely continue to lean into the US relationship, but Trump’s lame-duck status will ensure continued economic engagement with other foreign partners, including China.

Dramatic defeat will not change Trump’s regional policy, though cabinet changes could have an impact. In the aftermath of the midterm rout, Trump will likely remain focused on Latin America as he prioritizes both winning policy issues and his legacy. Indeed, most of Trump’s relevant policies toward the region rely on executive action. That includes trade authorities, the entire Venezuela sanctions and licensing framework, and security assistance for allies in the region, among others (see: Latin America Update, 28 October 2026).

Still, Congress will actively investigate multiple parts of Trump’s regional agenda, especially the Pentagon-North America Blue Energy Partners oil deal and US management of Venezuela oil revenues, which will likely be the subject of hearings (see: Unprecedented oil deal will reinforce Trump’s commitment to Rodriguez , 31 August 2026). Lawmakers will also likely scrutinize strikes targeting boats, and the use of El Salvador’s maximum-security prison for deportees. The administration is more likely to accelerate its efforts rather than pull back in the face of congressional pressure, focusing particularly on making the oil deal a durable part of the US-Venezuela relationship beyond 2028.

Potential cabinet changes would be more consequential. The scale of Trump’s defeat could accelerate the departures of key cabinet members who have outsized policy influence on the region. That’s particularly true of Rubio, who emerged from the midterms relatively better positioned for a competitive

presidential bid than Vice President JD Vance. But despite rumors of his exit, Rubio is likely to remain in the cabinet until near the end of 2027. First, the White House has yet to secure a win on Cuba, which is a highly personal issue for Rubio and appeals to Trump's increasing focus on his presidential legacy. The administration is likely to redouble its efforts on an economic deal with the island that includes symbolic political change such as President Miguel Diaz-Canel stepping aside or committing to a new vote. Rubio will likely seek to establish an electoral timeline in Venezuela before leaving his post as well.

Rubio key for Venezuela elections. Venezuela represents the Trump administration's single-biggest foreign policy success, but putting a transition in motion is also key for Rubio's political future, whether he seeks the GOP nomination in 2028 or 2032. He is the main proponent of competitive elections in Venezuela, and his tenure bodes well for progress toward a new vote. He is also likely to push for the start of debt restructuring talks in the coming months, which the White House views as part of the ongoing economic stabilization process. However, establishing an electoral timeline will remain his priority over wrapping up debt talks, with a possibility that negotiations with creditors extend through an eventual transition.

Midterm defeat represents setback for President Javier Milei. Bessant's future will likely have meaningful repercussions on the White House's inclination to provide Milei with extraordinary support ahead of next October's vote in Argentina. The Trump administration will remain supportive of Milei and other conservative allies in the region via multilateral support, an active US Development Finance Corporation, and security assistance. But the $20 billion currency swap from October 2025 is unlikely to be renewed in 2027 if Bessant is not there, given his personal role in implementing that policy tool (which Milei continues to tout as a potential financing source next year).

Bilateral relationship with Brazil will hold steady, midterm fallout is mixed bag for Mexico. President Trump has already signaled he won't take more punitive action against Brazil despite allegations of fraud in the election from the Bolsonaro camp, and he is more pragmatic in his stance toward President Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva than advisers in the Department of State. An embattled Trump reinforces that equilibrium, along with potential shake-ups in his cabinet. No tariff deal is likely, and Brazil's big tech regulation will create bilateral friction, but the status quo is likely to hold. Meanwhile, for Mexico, the results reinforce Eurasia Group's expectations of a trade deal, but Stephen Miller's appointment as White House chief of staff raises the risk of a harder security stance.

Conservative governments will continue to lean into Trump relationship, with hedging. Despite Trump's post-midterm weakness, conservative leaders in the region will likely continue to lean into the US relationship, given the potential security dividends. Most were elected on security platforms, and securing US support can help to bolster security credentials for figures such as President Daniel Noboa in Ecuador and Colombia's President Abelardo De la Espriella. Nevertheless, Trump's lame-duck status and the prospect of a Democrat in the White House in 2029 will likely lead to more hedging by Trump allies when it comes to economic partners, including continued engagement with China (see: EG Update , 31 August 2026).

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